

# Off the Shelf



## Gothic II

### RPG at its best

**F**lashback to *Gothic*: You find yourself thrown into a penal colony, sequestered from the rest of civilisation by a magical barrier—you can get into the colony, but you can't get out. After several joyous hours of playing the game, you discover that the secret to getting the barrier down lies with a creature called The Sleeper. By the end of *Gothic*, you have slain The Sleeper, and in the process, gotten yourself trapped in the rubble of its temple. The Sleeper, before being vanquished, called out to like-minded creatures to rally against the good folks of the land. The fall of the barrier actually boosted the Orcs, allowing them to spread all over the mining prison colony, cutting off the supply of precious ore. To make matters worse, the farmers are revolting against the king, and refuse to sell their harvest at a low price.

Despair echoes everywhere. The world's in quick need of a miracle, and this is your cue. The solution seems to lie in an ancient and sacred artefact called the Eye of Innos. Innos is the God of light and fire, and a brother to Beliar, the bad guy.

Since your former home is besieged by Orcs and Dragons, you'll find refuge in the harbour city of Khorinis. Three main guilds are sprinkled around within the

city—the Militia, Mercenaries, and the Monastery. The Militia are in service to the king, and are in the city on a secret mission. The Mercenaries guild was formed by the former convicts of the new camp at the Penal Colony—they're out and out fighters. In the Monastery, you're taught about Innos and the Magic Circle of Fire by the Fire Mages—the priests of Innos. But you'll need to join one of these guilds and progress in their ranks first. To join a guild, you need to become a citizen of Khorinis, and this is done by working with any of the masters as an apprentice: There is a hunter, an alchemist and a weapon-smith from which to choose.

The land of Khorinis is home to some very interesting characters—the pompous Fire Mages, the do-good Paladins and the cutthroat band of Mercenaries. Any of them will help you get to your goal, but only for their vested interests. The land is huge and filled with lush forests, deep valleys complete with waterfalls, and a ship-wrecked treasure island. Access to various areas has been restricted in an obtuse manner. Some areas are guarded by monsters that you can't challenge until you gain enough experience—or, you find a way around them, or a trick to defeat them.

The game looks a lot better than its predecessor. The forests are covered with lush bushes, and rays of sunshine peek through the dense canopy of trees. Take a swim in the ocean, and you'll be greeted by lashing waves that froth at the shore. For the kind of hardware requirements the game demands, it looks very good.

The controls might be a bit frustrating at first. Although this sequel has bet-



Not a very intellectual conversation..

ter mouse support, it is designed only for keyboard play. With time, the controls become second nature, and you'll come to appreciate the simplicity of it all. Combat is divided into two-handed and single-handed. You have to time both—your attack, and block—in order to win battles.

The most obvious flaw is the translation from German to English. While not completely bug-free, most bugs only look bad and don't interfere with the gameplay. One irritating flaw is if you press the wrong key at the wrong time during a conversation, the game gets stuck in a particular camera angle—until you restart.

If you really want to enjoy the game, play it at an easy pace. It can be rushed through, but you'll miss a lot. Take it slow; enjoy the beautifully created world and the characters that call it home. All the dialogues in the game are spoken, so there's little chance of you ever getting bored reading page after page of text. There are some good moments in the game, some funny, some emotional, some nostalgic. If you're a RPG fan and are dying to play a good game, this is it. Good RPGs are few and far in between, so don't miss this opportunity.



Uh-oh. Better get out of here while I still have my legs

**Genre:** RPG ■ **Developer:** Piranha Bytes ■ **Publisher:** Atari ■ **System Requirements:** 700 MHz CPU, 256 MB RAM, 32 MB video card, 2.2 GB hard disk space ■ **Price:** US\$ 39.90 ■ **Web site:** [www.gothic2.com](http://www.gothic2.com)  
**Rating:** ★★★★★